‘democratic principles of contiguity of majority areas’.[15] The grouse was against the partitioning of Punjab, or the districts of Gurdaspur and Lahore to be more specific, where some Muslim-majority sub-districts contiguous to West Punjab were retained in India. The border stayed put but people did not. On the western side, over 6 million people poured into Pakistan, and close to 5 million moved to the Indian side, along with an estimated 2 million casualties.[16] Undivided Punjab had half the population of undivided Bengal but the displacements and casualties were more than double on the western frontier than in the east. This is why, in public memory, the Partition of 1947 is more closely associated with Punjab than Bengal.

Punjab differed from Bengal in two important aspects. First, it housed three numerically significant religions rather than two. Muslims, Hindu and Sikhs made up roughly a half, third and sixth of the population of undivided Punjab respectively. Many districts had thin majorities, and in some no religion enjoyed an absolute majority. Geographically and emotionally, Sikhs got the rawest deal because the Radcliffe line ran right through the centre of their homeland, with important shrines on both sides. The demographic case to move was thus felt stronger in Punjab than in Bengal. In addition, undivided Punjab was home to a large number of the 2.5 million-strong British Indian army that had served a few years earlier in World War II. As one research study has shown, war veterans had exposure to combat experience that fostered particular organizational skills useful for co-ethnic immigration and minority ethnic cleansing.[17] Building on the communal clashes of 1946–47, the level of violence unleashed by this potent mix of hatred and organizational skill was truly horrific as blood-stained trains rolled across the borders, vividly captured in Khushwant Singh’s novel *A Train to Pakistan.* People ran for their life, and at least one such escapee, Milkha Singh, would continue running long after, representing India in professional athletics at the highest levels. As news of mass murder and rape filtered through at each end, more minority families were convinced of the need to migrate, even if they did not intend to do so. They were gripped by a kind of fear that was poignantly described by novelist Amitav Ghosh in *The Shadow Lines:*[18]